

Gauntlet v0.6.2 Reference Guide

Compact tableside reference · Published August 5, 2026

Gauntlet v0.6.2 Reference Guide

Status: Published compact reference **Version:** v0.6.2

Your Turn

Capture → Draw → Opening → Movement → Denouement → Cleanup

Capture

If your token is beyond your **Front Line**, capture the next opposing Territory immediately beyond that line.

- Your controlled Territories must remain contiguous from your own end.
- Your position may extend beyond your control.
- Normal Capture advances your Front Line by at most one Territory per turn.

Draw

Draw one card.

Opening

You may take your Action now.

Movement

Choose one:

- **Advance:** move one position toward the opponent's end.
- **Hold:** remain where you are.
- **Fall Back:** move one position toward your own end.

Entering the opponent's position creates a pending battle and ends the current movement sequence.

Denouement

You may take your Action now if you did not take it during Opening.

Cleanup

Resolve end-of-turn effects and discard down to the Hand limit. Pass the active-player marker.

Actions

Each turn, normally take **one Action** during either Opening or Denouement.

An Action may:

- play one card for its **Action** effect;
- take one legal **Faction Action**; or
- discard one Asset you control.

Normally take no more than one Action during either phase.

An additional Action does not by itself permit two Actions during the same phase.

A **Faction Action** lists the phase in which it is legal.

A **Faction Ability** occurs at its stated timing and does not use an Action unless it says otherwise.

Pending Battle and Terms

Pending battle → Terms → Onset → Gambits

Before Onset:

1. establish the attacker, defender, contested position, and the attacker's previous position;
2. resolve the Terms timing if a Diplomat is involved; and
3. proceed according to the decision.

Accepted Terms

Apply the Proposal's Accepted effect. No battle begins.

Unless the Proposal says otherwise:

The attacker withdraws. The defender remains at the contested position.

No Onset, Gambit, Reserve, Tactic, Outcome, or Aftermath occurs.

Refused or no Terms

Proceed to **Onset**.

Battle

Onset → set Gambits → form Reserves → reveal Gambits → choose Tactics → reveal Tactics → Outcome → Aftermath

Onset

Onset begins the battle. Resolve Onset effects before Gambits are set.

Outcome

The higher battle total wins.

Defensive Edge

Defensive Edge: When the defender has Defensive Edge, the defender wins tied battle totals.

The defender normally has Defensive Edge when:

- the defender controls the contested Territory; or
- the defender is making a Last Stand.

An effect may remove Defensive Edge, including an applicable Arena Territory effect.

Tiebreak Roll

If the tie remains unresolved:

Each player rolls one die. Do not apply advantage, disadvantage, card effects, numerical modifiers, or the previous battle totals. Higher roll wins. Reroll further ties.

Only an effect that expressly refers to a **Tiebreak Roll** may modify it.

Retreat and Withdrawal

A losing player retreats; a player who leaves without losing withdraws.

Retreat and withdrawal normally move a player the same way:

- attacker: return to the position from which they entered;
- defender: move one position toward their own end;
- only the attacker withdraws: the defender remains in the contested position;
- only the defender withdraws: the attacker remains in the contested position and becomes the occupier when applicable;
- both withdraw: move the attacker first, then the defender; neither becomes the occupier because of the withdrawal.

Retreat

- follows a battle loss;
- the battle has a winner and loser;
- win, loss, retreat, Occupation, and other result effects apply.

Withdrawal

- ends or prevents a pending or active battle without a winner;
- win, loss, and retreat effects do not occur;
- before Onset: no battle or Aftermath occurs;
- after Onset: complete the remaining non-result steps of the Aftermath and clear any committed battle cards using their normal destinations.

Fall Back is ordinary Movement. It is neither retreat nor withdrawal.

Front Line

Your **Front Line** is the unbroken sequence of Territories you control from your own end.

- Control cannot skip an opposing Territory.
- Your token may move beyond your Front Line.
- During Capture, add the next opposing Territory immediately beyond your Front Line if your token is on or beyond it.
- The captured Territory may be behind your token.
- Deep position alone does not capture the opponent's final Territory or open the Last Stand.

Core Vocabulary

Term	Meaning
Opening	Action phase before Movement.
Denouement	Action phase after Movement and any resulting battle.
Faction Action	Faction-specific option chosen when taking an Action; lists its legal phase.
Faction Ability	Faction-specific effect at its own timing; does not use an Action unless stated.
Fall Back	Ordinary Movement one position toward your own end.
Pending battle	Pre-battle state before Onset.
Onset	Opening stage of an active battle.
Aftermath	Closing stage of an active battle.
Defensive Edge	Conditional benefit that causes the defender to win tied battle totals.
Tiebreak Roll	Separate unmodified one-die sudden-death roll.
Front Line	Contiguous controlled Territories from your own end.
Retreat	Displacement after losing a battle.
Withdraw	Leave or prevent a battle without determining a winner.

Gauntlet v0.6.2 First Game Guide

Teaching order and tableside procedures · Published August 5, 2026

Gauntlet v0.6.2 First Game and Tableside Guide

Status: Published player aid **Version:** v0.6.2

1. First-game teaching order

Teach in three layers:

1. **The shared game** — the turn, Movement, one ordinary battle, Occupation, Capture, and running the Gauntlet.
2. **Your faction** — its resource or progression, Leader, Faction Actions and Abilities, and additional victory.
3. **The opponent's faction** — only the public information needed to make decisions against it.

Do not begin by reading both complete faction guides aloud. Each player receives one authoritative tableside faction reference for their own faction and one concise opponent summary for the opposing faction.

Before faction rules

Physically demonstrate:

1. one ordinary turn;
2. one ordinary battle with Hand, Gambit, Reserve, and Tactic visibly separated;
3. Fall Back, withdrawal, and retreat as three different movements;
4. an attacker becoming the occupier after winning;
5. Capture advancing the Front Line on a later turn; and
6. a bound card placed beneath the effect that binds it.

Only after this shared demonstration should each player learn their faction overlay.

2. Shared tableside turn reference

Capture → Draw → Opening → Movement → Denouement → Cleanup

Capture

If the active player's token is on or beyond the next opposing Territory immediately beyond their Front Line, add that Territory to their Front Line.

- Control remains contiguous from the player's own end.
- Position may extend beyond control.
- Normal Capture advances the Front Line by at most one Territory.

Draw

Draw one card.

Opening

The active player may take their Action now.

Movement

Choose one:

- **Advance:** move one Position toward the opponent's end;
- **Hold:** remain in the current Position; or
- **Fall Back:** move one Position toward the active player's own end.

Entering the opponent's Position creates a pending battle and ends the current Movement sequence.

Denouement

The active player may take their Action now if they did not take it during Opening.

Cleanup

Resolve end-of-turn effects, discard down to the Hand limit, and pass the active-player marker.

Action reminder

A player normally takes one Action during either Opening or Denouement.

An Action may:

- play a card for its Action effect;
- take a legal Faction Action; or
- discard one Asset the player controls.

An additional Action does not by itself permit two Actions in one phase.

3. Shared tableside battle reference

Pending battle

Pending battle → Terms → Onset → Gambits

1. Establish attacker, defender, contested Position, and the attacker's previous Position.
2. Resolve Terms if a Diplomat is involved.
3. Accepted Terms prevent the battle.
4. Refused Terms or no Terms proceed to Onset.

Active battle

Onset → set Gambits → form Reserves → reveal Gambits → choose Tactics → reveal Tactics → Outcome → Aftermath

Onset

Resolve effects used during Onset before Gambits are set.

Gambit

Each player may set one eligible card from Hand face down. The card is no longer in Hand while it is in battle.

Reserve

Each player normally draws three cards into a temporary private Reserve.

Tactic

Each player may normally choose one eligible card from Reserve. Cards left in Reserve remain separate from Hand.

Outcome

Apply active effects, roll, and compare battle totals.

- When the defender has **Defensive Edge**, the defender wins tied battle totals.
- If the tie remains unresolved, make a separate unmodified **Tiebreak Roll**.
- Higher Tiebreak Roll wins; reroll further ties.

Aftermath

Apply the result, retreat the loser, establish Occupation when applicable, resolve Aftermath effects, and clear battle cards to their normal destinations.

4. Movement and result diagram

Use this verbal and visual distinction on every player reference:

Fall Back is ordinary Movement. A losing player retreats. A player who leaves without losing withdraws.

Fall Back

- chosen during the active player's normal Movement;
- moves one Position toward that player's own end;
- does not involve a battle result.

Retreat

- follows a battle loss;
- creates a winner and loser;
- triggers win, loss, retreat, and Occupation consequences.

Withdrawal

- ends or prevents a pending or active battle without a winner;
- triggers no win, loss, or retreat effects;
- before Onset, produces no battle or Aftermath;
- after Onset, completes the remaining non-result Aftermath and clears committed cards normally.

Occupation and Capture

1. An attacker wins on an opposing controlled Territory.
 2. The defender retreats.
 3. The attacker remains and becomes the **occupier**.
 4. Control does not change yet.
 5. If the attacker remains on or beyond the next Territory beyond their Front Line until a later Capture step, that Territory joins the Front Line.
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5. Player-mat and zone specification

Each player mat must provide clearly separated labeled areas for:

- Draw Pile;
- Hand;
- Discard Pile;
- Graveyard;
- Asset Bank;
- Leader and faction components;
- Gambit;
- Reserve;
- Tactic;
- current Territory / Player Token relationship; and
- temporary bound cards.

The Hand remains the player's permanent private cards. Reserve is a separate temporary private zone used only during the current battle.

Battle-zone layout

Arrange battle zones in play order:

Hand → Gambit | Reserve → Tactic

The Gambit area should sit between the Hand and battle center. The Reserve and Tactic areas should be visibly separate so an unchosen Reserve card cannot be mistaken for a Tactic or Hand card.

Faction areas

- **Military:** Leader and Command tracker.
- **Diplomats:** Leader, Influence tracker, Proposal row, and ratified Treaty Articles.
- **Financiers:** Leader, Capital ledger, Treasury, and owned Deeds.
- **Intelligence:** Leader, Intel, Operation Progress, Active Mission or Special Operation.
- **Mystics:** Leader, three Rites, Ritual area, and bound-card spaces.
- **Inquisition:** Leader, Conviction tracker, doctrine, and Purge reference.

6. Bound-card diagram and reminder

A bound card is physically tucked beneath or placed immediately beside the effect that binds it, with enough of the card visible to identify it when public.

BOUND — outside Hand, Draw Pile, Discard Pile, Graveyard, Reserve, Tactic, and Asset Bank

- A face-up bound card is public.
- A face-down bound card may be inspected only by its owner.
- It cannot be played, moved, or affected except by the effect to which it is bound.
- The binding effect determines where it goes when the binding ends.

For Mystics Rites and the Ritual, the mat should show dedicated slots beneath the relevant Rite or Ritual reference. For Extraordinary Rendition, place the selected opposing card face up beneath the Asset.

7. Active-player marker

The active-player marker is a shared physical object passed after Cleanup.

Required face text

YOUR TURN

Capture → Draw → Opening → Movement → Denouement → Cleanup

Required reminder text

- Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.
- Pass this marker after Cleanup.

The marker tracks only whose turn it is and the shared turn sequence. It does not track battle initiative, priority, Actions remaining, or the attacker.

Its final illustration, shape, stock, and production form remain open for the release-production pass.

8. Faction teaching cards

Each faction reference uses the same order:

1. aim;
2. resource or progression;
3. Faction Actions;
4. Faction Abilities and public timing windows;
5. additional victory;
6. Leader comparison;
7. recommended starter Deck;
8. first-turn plan; and
9. opponent summary.

Military

Your faction

- **Aim:** Win battles, gain Command, and convert momentum into movement and control.
- **Resource:** Command, maximum 2. Gain 1 the first time each turn Military wins a battle.
- **Faction Actions:** None.
- **Faction Abilities:** Orders at their printed timings.
- **Additional victory:** None; Military runs the Gauntlet.
- **General:** Attacks repeatedly and carries momentum forward.
- **Commandant:** Defends controlled ground and turns defensive wins into pressure.
- **Recommended first Leader:** General.
- **Starter Decks:** Forward Doctrine / Holdfast.

Opponent summary

Track Command. Military may add movement, modify a battle, push a retreat farther, or advance its Front Line after a win. Invasion can enlarge an attacking Reserve and Tactic limit, but unused Invasion movement ends when a pending battle is created.

Diplomats

Your faction

- **Aim:** Offer Terms, ratify different Proposals, and reshape battles through agreement or refusal.
- **Resource:** Influence, 0–10; begin with 1.
- **Faction Actions:** None.
- **Faction procedure:** Offer Terms during a pending battle before Onset.
- **Faction Ability:** Leverage after refused Terms before dice.
- **Additional victory:** Peace Treaty after five different Proposals are ratified.
- **Ambassador:** Gains card flow from accepted Terms.
- **Senator:** Risks larger Stakes and preserves Influence after setbacks.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Ambassador.
- **Starter Decks:** Open Channels / Procedure Endures.

Opponent summary

Read the Proposal before accepting or refusing. Accepted Terms prevent the battle; refusal proceeds to Onset. The Diplomat gains more Influence by imposing a newly ratified Proposal after a win, and Détente rewards acceptance only when the Proposal was already ratified when offered.

Financiers

Your faction

- **Aim:** Build Capital and Treasury value, buy Deeds, and combine ownership with territorial pressure.
- **Resource:** Capital; begin with 2 for the v0.6.2 test.
- **Faction Actions:** Treasury, Deed purchase, Play the Market, and Hostile Takeover during Denouement.
- **Faction Ability:** Subsidize before dice; Financial Capacity may permit an Action in both Opening and Denouement.
- **Additional victory:** Own the Deeds to every Territory through Controlling Interest.
- **Banker:** Uses cards as controlled collateral for purchases.
- **Executive:** Converts offensive Occupation into Deed ownership and Front Line control.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Executive.
- **Starter Decks:** Sound Investment / Hostile Expansion.

Opponent summary

Capital, Treasury, and Deeds are public. Financial Capacity may give the Financier both Action phases, provided one Action is a Financier Faction Action. Deed ownership does not itself equal Territory control.

Intelligence

Your faction

- **Aim:** Complete Missions, gain Intel and Operation Progress, and prepare a Special Operation.
- **Resources:** Intel and Operation Progress.
- **Faction Actions:** Start, complete, or abort a Mission; start or complete a Special Operation, all during Denouement.
- **Faction Abilities:** Surveillance, Interference, Fieldcraft, and Mission Control at their stated timings.
- **Additional victory:** Complete a ready Special Operation.
- **Ranger:** Uses Fieldcraft and terrain knowledge for flexible operations.
- **Spymaster:** Chains Missions through Mission Control.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Ranger.
- **Starter Decks:** Field Operations / Mission Network.

Opponent summary

Mission identity is hidden, but Intel and Operation Progress are public. Intelligence may reveal and interfere with a face-down Gambit and later with face-down Tactics. Replacements do not create a new information window.

Mystics

Your faction

- **Aim:** Complete three Rites, unlock Invocation, Transmutation, and Convergence, then complete the Ritual of Ascendance.
- **Progression:** Three public Rites; no resource tracker.
- **Faction Actions:** Begin a Rite or begin the Ritual during Denouement, except Nature's Altar may permit Begin a Rite during Opening.
- **Faction Abilities:** Rite completion, Invocation, Transmutation, Convergence, and Leader abilities.
- **Additional victory:** Initiate and win a battle while the three Ritual cards remain bound.
- **Alchemist:** Replaces deliberate sacrifice with card flow.
- **Spirit Walker:** Protects Rite and Ritual progress after a loss.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Spirit Walker.
- **Starter Decks:** First Principles / Unbroken Circle.

Opponent summary

Completed Rites and bound cards are public when face up. The Spirit Walker may prevent interruption by sacrificing an Arcane card with value 1, 2, 3, or 4 according to progress. Nature's Altar requires token presence to begin and control at completion timing for its same-turn exception.

Inquisition

Your faction

- **Aim:** Build Conviction, move opposing cards permanently into the Graveyard, and use Purge to remove options.
- **Resource:** Conviction, maximum 4.
- **Faction Action:** Purge during Opening or Denouement. A Purge Action permits one Action in each phase, provided one is Purge.
- **Faction Abilities:** Condemnation, Blasphemy, Final Judgment, and Relentless Pursuit.
- **Additional victory:** Purification when the opponent cannot make the normal start-of-turn draw because both Draw Pile and Discard Pile are empty.
- **Grand Inquisitor:** Converts battle wins into discounted Purges.
- **Witch Hunter:** Punishes failed attacks with immediate pursuit.
- **Recommended first Leader:** Grand Inquisitor.
- **Starter Decks:** Final Judgment / Relentless Pursuit.

Opponent summary

Opposing Tactics normally go to the Graveyard in battles against Inquisition. Track Conviction before playing Arcane cards or attacking the Witch Hunter. Martyrdom does not prevent a loss, but it can send cards remaining in the winner's Reserve to the Graveyard.

9. Introductory pairings

Preferred first pairing

Military — General vs Inquisition — Grand Inquisitor

Why:

- both players use the shared battle game directly;
- both resources are public and capped;
- neither player must learn hidden objectives or negotiation procedure first;
- each Leader demonstrates a clear win-to-resource loop; and
- the matchup teaches Graveyard consequences without requiring a second board subsystem.

Alternative first pairings

- **Military — Commandant vs Financiers — Executive:** defense and Occupation against direct acquisition.
- **Diplomats — Ambassador vs Military — General:** introduces Terms against an otherwise direct opponent.
- **Intelligence — Ranger vs Inquisition — Grand Inquisitor:** introduces hidden information while keeping the opposing faction public.

Pairings to reserve for a guided host

- Intelligence vs Mystics;
- Diplomats vs Intelligence;
- Financiers mirror;
- Diplomats mirror; and
- any pairing where both players are simultaneously learning hidden objectives, extensive interrupts, or alternate-victory sequencing.

These are teaching recommendations, not balance judgments or restrictions.

10. Five-minute guided first battle

Before beginning the actual game:

1. Place both Player Tokens together on a sample contested Territory.
2. Name an attacker and defender.
3. Skip Terms unless demonstrating Diplomats.
4. Announce **Onset**.
5. Each player takes any one card from the top of their Deck and places it face down as a sample Gambit.
6. Each player takes three more cards as a sample Reserve.
7. Each chooses one sample Tactic.
8. Reveal the sample Gambits and Tactics without applying printed effects.
9. Roll and identify whether Defensive Edge or a Tiebreak Roll would apply.
10. Demonstrate the loser's retreat, the attacker's Occupation when applicable, and the normal card destinations.
11. Return all demonstration cards, shuffle both Decks, reset the tokens, and begin normal setup draws.

This dry run teaches physical zones and result movement without altering the actual game or requiring players to understand four unfamiliar card effects at once.

11. Starter Deck presentation

For each recommended first-game Deck, present:

- Deck name;
- Leader and faction;
- one-sentence plan;
- Opening plan;

- four signature cards;
- Territory order from the player's own end outward;
- first-game tip;
- opponent watch text; and
- exact 30-card list and 60-value total.

Do not describe the starter as a reduced card pool. It is a coherent recommended Deck built from the full legal pool.

The published Deckbuilder and `/start/` flow use this release's canonical data and starter catalog.

12. Authority and release boundary

For the v0.6.2 release:

1. The Official Rulebook and specific component text govern play.
2. `Gauntlet_v0.6.2_Starter_Decks.json` governs the twelve recommended starter compositions.
3. This document governs first-game and tableside presentation.
4. v0.6.1 remains available as an immutable historical release package.

Later layout work may change typography, iconography, dimensions, and illustration, but it may not change the sequences, terminology, faction summaries, or starter compositions without a recorded superseding decision.

Player Mat

Player _____
Faction _____ Leader _____

YOUR TURN: Capture - Draw - Opening - Movement - Denouement - Cleanup
Take one Action during Opening or Denouement. Pass the active-player marker after Cleanup.

Hand

Permanent private cards

Begin with 3. During Cleanup, discard down to the normal Hand limit.

Draw Pile

Face down

Discard

Recyclable

Graveyard

Normally permanent

Bound Cards

Outside normal zones

Tuck each card beneath or beside the effect that binds it. A bound card cannot be played, moved, or affected except by that effect.

Position & Front Line

Token location is not control

Your Front Line is the contiguous Territories you control from your own end. During Capture, add at most the next opposing Territory immediately beyond it when your token is on or beyond that Territory.

Battle Staging

Clear after each active battle

Pending Battle / Onset

Terms occur before Onset

Establish attacker, defender, contested Position, and attack origin. Accepted Terms prevent the battle. Refused or no Terms proceed to Onset.

Fall Back
ordinary Movement

Retreat
after losing

Withdraw
leave without a winner

Gambit

From Hand

Normally set up to one face down after Onset.

Aftermath: Graveyard

Tactic

From Reserve

Normally choose up to one after Gambits resolve.

Aftermath: Discard Pile

Reserve

Temporary private zone

Set Hand physically aside. Normally draw 3 cards here. Unchosen Reserve cards remain separate from Hand and go to the Discard Pile during Aftermath.

1 Onset

2 Set Gambits

3 Form Reserves

4 Reveal Gambits

5 Choose Tactics

6 Reveal Tactics

7 Outcome

8 Aftermath

Leader & Faction

Public components

Keep the Leader and faction trackers, references, Proposals, Deeds, Missions, Rites, doctrine, or other public components visible here.

Asset Bank

Public persistent cards

Limit equals Territories you control. When full, discard a controlled Asset to make room unless a rule prevents it from leaving.

Action Reminder

Normally one total

During Opening or Denouement: play one Action effect, take one legal Faction Action, or discard one Asset. An additional Action does not itself permit two Actions in one phase.

Outcome Reminder

Resolve ties correctly

Defensive Edge lets the defender win tied battle totals. If the tie remains, make a separate unmodified Tiebreak Roll; reroll further ties.

Occupation & Capture

Control changes later

After an attacking win, the attacker may become the occupier. Control normally changes only during a later Capture step when contiguous Front Line requirements are met.

Gauntlet Playtest Sheet

Record what happened before proposing a fix. One unusual game is evidence, not a verdict.

SESSION
QR

Sheet serial
Scan to start or join this
sheet's tracked session.

Date _____ Session / group _____ Facilitator _____

Instruction + setup _____ Game time _____ Total session _____ Rules lookup _____

Test type: ☐ First game ☐ Repeated matchup ☐ Leader comparison ☐ Custom Deck ☐ Rules/components

Player A

Name / ID _____

Faction / Leader _____

Deck _____

Recommended? ☐ Yes ☐ Modified ☐ No

Faction teaching card used? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Player B

Name / ID _____

Faction / Leader _____

Deck _____

Recommended? ☐ Yes ☐ Modified ☐ No

Faction teaching card used? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Outcome and completion

First player: ☐ A ☐ B Winner: ☐ A ☐ B ☐ None Rounds _____ Battles _____

Ended by: ☐ Normal victory ☐ Concession ☐ Time ☐ Rules blocker ☐ Component/technical issue ☐ Other

Victory route: ☐ Ran the Gauntlet ☐ Peace Treaty ☐ Controlling Interest ☐ Special Operation ☐ Ritual ☐ Purification

Player ratings - circle 1 (poor) through 5 (excellent)

Question	A	B	Question	A	B
Overall fun	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	Pacing	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5
Meaningful decisions	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	Battle tension	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5
Rules clarity	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	Faction / Leader clarity	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5
Table organization	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5	Would play again	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5

v0.6.2 procedure checks

☐ Turn sequence stayed clear ☐ Opening vs Denouement caused confusion ☐ Pending battle / Terms / Onset caused confusion

☐ Defensive Edge / Tiebreak Roll caused confusion

☐ Front Line vs Position caused confusion ☐ Fall Back / retreat / withdrawal caused confusion ☐ Battle zones became mixed ☐ Bound cards became unclear

What worked best?

What dragged or frustrated?

What required a ruling?

Best moment / hardest decision

Detailed Observations

Battle and movement record

#	Attacker	Territory / Position	Terms?	Result	Notable rule/card interaction
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					

Did any of these occur?

- ☐ Winner clear long before the end
- ☐ Repetitive or low-stakes battles
- ☐ Player had no meaningful options
- ☐ Attacking felt consistently futile
- ☐ Territory / Asset loss snowballed too hard
- ☐ Additional victory felt solitary or irrelevant
- ☐ Card flow or Graveyard pressure broke down
- ☐ Rules, zones, or components interrupted play
- ☐ Starter Deck did not present its plan
- ☐ Opponent summary omitted needed information

Most confusing rule, card, or timing window	Anything too strong, too weak, or automatic?
Did a faction procedure distract from the shared game?	Did any printed aid fail to answer a routine question?
Most important thing to investigate next	Other observations / exact wording remembered

Facilitator classification

- ☐ Rules defect
- ☐ Wording defect
- ☐ Teaching defect
- ☐ Component/layout defect
- ☐ Balance signal
- ☐ Technical defect
- ☐ No action yet

Military

Aim: Win battles, gain Command, and convert momentum into movement and control.
Resource: Command, maximum 2. Gain 1 the first time each turn Military wins a battle.
Faction Actions: None. Orders are Faction Abilities at their printed timings.
Victory: Run the Gauntlet.
General: attacks repeatedly and carries momentum forward. **Commandant:** defends controlled ground and turns defensive wins into pressure.
Recommended first Leader: General. **Starter:** Forward Doctrine.

FIRST-TURN PLAN

Establish your movement line, preserve a useful Gambit, and look for the first battle that can begin the Command loop.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Track Command. Military can add movement, modify battle totals, extend a retreat, or advance its Front Line after a win. Invasion can enlarge an attacking Reserve and Tactic limit, but its unused movement ends when a pending battle is created.

Diplomats

Aim: Offer Terms, ratify different Proposals, and reshape battles through agreement or refusal.
Resource: Influence, 0-10; begin with 1.
Procedure: Offer Terms during a pending battle before Onset. Use Leverage before dice after refused Terms.
Victory: Peace Treaty after five different Proposals are ratified.
Ambassador: gains card flow from accepted Terms. **Senator:** risks larger Stakes and preserves Influence after setbacks.
Recommended first Leader: Ambassador. **Starter:** Open Channels.

FIRST-TURN PLAN

Build enough Influence to make refusal costly, then offer a Proposal whose accepted and refused results both advance your plan.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Read the Proposal before accepting or refusing. Accepted Terms prevent the battle; refusal proceeds to Onset. Newly ratified Proposals grant Influence. Détente rewards acceptance only when the Proposal was already ratified when offered.

Financiers

Aim: Build Capital and Treasury value, buy Deeds, and combine ownership with territorial pressure.

Resource: Capital; begin with 2 for v0.6.2 testing.

Faction Actions: Treasury, Deed purchase, Play the Market, and Hostile Takeover during Denouement.

Ability: Subsidize before dice. Financial Capacity may permit one Action in Opening and one in Denouement when one is a Financier Faction Action.

Victory: Own the Deeds to every Territory through Controlling Interest.

Banker: uses cards as controlled collateral. **Executive:** converts offensive Occupation into ownership and control.

Recommended first Leader: Executive. **Starter:** Hostile Expansion.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Capital, Treasury, and Deeds are public. Financial Capacity may give both Action phases, but at least one Action must be a Financier Faction Action. Deed ownership does not itself equal Territory control.

Intelligence

Aim: Complete Missions, gain Intel and Operation Progress, and prepare a Special Operation.

Resources: Intel and Operation Progress.

Faction Actions: Start, complete, or abort a Mission; start or complete a Special Operation, all during Denouement.

Abilities: Surveillance, Interference, Fieldcraft, and Mission Control at their stated timings.

Victory: Complete a ready Special Operation.

Ranger: uses Fieldcraft and terrain knowledge. **Spymaster:** chains Missions through Mission Control.

Recommended first Leader: Ranger. **Starter:** Field Operations.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Mission identity is hidden, but Intel and Operation Progress are public. Intelligence may inspect and interfere with a face-down Gambit and later face-down Tactics. Replacements do not create a new information window.

Mystics

Aim: Complete three Rites, unlock faction abilities, then complete the Ritual of Ascendance.

Progression: Three public Rites; no resource tracker.

Faction Actions: Begin a Rite or begin the Ritual during Denouement. Nature's Altar may permit Begin a Rite during Opening.

Victory: Initiate and win a battle while the three Ritual cards remain bound.

Alchemist: replaces deliberate sacrifice with card flow. **Spirit Walker:** protects Rite and Ritual progress after a loss.

Recommended first Leader: Spirit Walker. **Starter:** Unbroken Circle.

FIRST-TURN PLAN

Choose the Rite that best fits your opening cards. Keep Arcane value available if the Spirit Walker may need to prevent interruption.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Completed Rites and face-up bound cards are public. The Spirit Walker may sacrifice Arcane value 1, 2, 3, or 4 according to progress. Nature's Altar requires token presence to begin and control at completion timing for its same-turn exception.

Inquisition

Aim: Build Conviction, move opposing cards permanently into the Graveyard, and use Purge to remove options.

Resource: Conviction, maximum 4.

Faction Action: Purge during Opening or Denouement. A Purge Action permits one Action in each phase when one is Purge.

Abilities: Condemnation, Blasphemy, Final Judgment, and Relentless Pursuit.

Victory: Purification when the opponent cannot make the normal start-of-turn draw because both Draw Pile and Discard Pile are empty.

Grand Inquisitor: converts wins into discounted Purges. **Witch Hunter:** punishes failed attacks with pursuit.

Recommended first Leader: Grand Inquisitor. **Starter:** Final Judgment.

OPPONENT SUMMARY

Opposing Tactics normally go to the Graveyard in battles against Inquisition. Track Conviction before playing Arcane cards or attacking the Witch Hunter. Martyrdom does not prevent a loss, but it can send cards remaining in the winner's Reserve to the Graveyard.

Active-Player Markers

CUT · FOLD · PASS AFTER CLEANUP

Purpose: The marker tracks only whose turn it is and the shared turn sequence. It does not track battle initiative, priority, Actions remaining, or the attacker.

Gauntlet v0.6.2

YOUR TURN

CAPTURE - DRAW - OPENING
MOVEMENT - DENOUEMENT - CLEANUP

Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.
Pass this marker after Cleanup.

FOLD

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YOUR TURN

CAPTURE - DRAW - OPENING
MOVEMENT - DENOUEMENT - CLEANUP

Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.
Pass this marker after Cleanup.

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YOUR TURN

CAPTURE - DRAW - OPENING
MOVEMENT - DENOUEMENT - CLEANUP

Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.
Pass this marker after Cleanup.

FOLD

Gauntlet v0.6.2

YOUR TURN

CAPTURE - DRAW - OPENING
MOVEMENT - DENOUEMENT - CLEANUP

Take one Action during Opening or Denouement.
Pass this marker after Cleanup.

For repeated use, tape the inside edges after folding or place a small binder clip at the base.

What Changed in Gauntlet v0.6.2

Returning-player handout · Published August 5, 2026

What Changed in Gauntlet v0.6.2

Status: Published returning-player guide **Release tracker:** [#470](#) **Closeout tracker:** [#506](#) **Document tracker:** [#503](#)

This handout explains what a player who already knows v0.6.1 must do differently in v0.6.2. It is organized around play at the table, not repository implementation history.

v0.6.2 is the current canonical playtest release. v0.6.1 remains available as an immutable historical package.

Change labels

- **Mechanical change:** the game now plays differently.
- **Terminology change:** the procedure is substantially familiar, but its formal name or presentation changed.
- **Clarification:** the rule is now stated more precisely to prevent inconsistent readings.
- **Test revision:** intentionally adopted for v0.6.2 playtesting and subject to later evaluation.

At a glance

The changes most likely to affect every game are:

1. **[Mechanical change] Turns now have six named phases:** Capture, Draw, Opening, Movement, Denouement, Cleanup.
2. **[Mechanical change] Your normal Action may be taken during Opening or saved for Denouement.** An additional Action does not by itself allow two Actions in the same phase.
3. **[Terminology change] Ordinary Movement choices are Advance, Hold, and Fall Back.** Fall Back is not retreat or withdrawal.
4. **[Mechanical change] A collision first creates a pending battle.** Terms occur before Onset; accepted Terms prevent the battle from beginning.
5. **[Terminology change] Onset is the formal opening stage of an active battle.** Gambits follow Onset.
6. **[Mechanical change] Tied battles use Defensive Edge or a separate Tiebreak Roll.** The original modified battle totals are not rerolled.
7. **[Mechanical change] Territory control must remain contiguous.** Your token's Position may extend beyond your controlled Front Line without granting isolated control.
8. **[Clarification] Retreat, withdrawal, and Fall Back are different events** even when they move a token in the same direction.
9. **[Mechanical change] Recommended starter Decks now use each Leader's full legal pool.** Basic and Advanced are no longer active construction restrictions.
10. **[Mechanical change] Seven card titles are new or moved between pools,** and several inherited cards, Territories, Proposals, and faction procedures have compatibility revisions.

Setup and starting Decks

Recommended starter Decks

[Mechanical change] All twelve Leader starter Decks have been rebuilt from their full legal construction pools. A recommended starter is still a legal 30-card, 60-value Deck with three Territories, but it is no longer restricted by the retired Basic/Advanced teaching split.

Use the printed v0.6.2 starter for the selected Leader rather than carrying forward a v0.6.1 list.

Card complexity labels

[Terminology change] Basic and Advanced no longer determine whether a card may appear in a starter Deck or teaching game. Complexity may still be communicated for player guidance, but it is not an active construction rule.

First-game materials

[Clarification] v0.6.2 separates the complete rules from first-game guidance and tableside references. New players should follow the first-game sequence and faction summary supplied with their Leader rather than infer procedure from card text alone.

A shared active-player marker may be passed after Cleanup to help track long interactive turns.

Turn and Movement

The turn sequence

[Mechanical change] Complete each turn in this order:

Capture → Draw → Opening → Movement → Denouement → Cleanup

Capture now occurs before the normal draw. Resolve effects and victory checks following Capture before proceeding to Draw.

Actions

[Mechanical change] You normally take one Action total during either Opening or Denouement.

An Action may:

- play a card for its Action effect;
- take a legal Faction Action; or
- discard an Asset you control.

A Faction Ability occurs at its stated timing and does not use an Action unless it expressly says otherwise.

No more than one Action may normally be taken during Opening, and no more than one during Denouement. An effect granting an additional Action increases the total available that turn; it does not automatically increase either phase's capacity.

Movement choices

[Terminology change] During ordinary Movement, choose:

- **Advance:** move one Position toward the opponent's end;
- **Hold:** remain in place and end the current Movement sequence;
- **Fall Back:** move one Position toward your own end.

Entering the opponent's Position creates a pending battle and immediately ends that Movement sequence. Any unused movement from that sequence is lost even if Terms later prevent the battle.

Battles

Pending battle, Terms, and Onset

[Mechanical change] The pre-battle sequence is:

Pending battle → Terms → Onset → Gambits

The attacker, defender, contested Position, and attack origin are established when the pending battle is created.

Terms occur before Onset. A pending battle is not yet an active battle, so battle, win, loss, retreat, and Aftermath triggers do not occur unless the battle reaches Onset.

If Terms are accepted, resolve the Proposal's Accepted effect. Unless that Proposal gives another positional result, the attacker withdraws to the attack origin and the defender remains at the contested Position. There is no Onset, battle result, Occupation caused by the accepted Terms, or Aftermath.

If Terms are refused or none are offered, proceed to Onset.

Onset

[Terminology change] Onset replaces informal references to battle opening effects. During Onset, the pending battle becomes active, roles are fixed, and effects that apply during Onset or when the battle begins resolve before Gambits.

Defensive Edge

[Mechanical change] A defender with Defensive Edge wins tied battle totals.

The defender normally has Defensive Edge while defending a Territory they control or making a Last Stand. Merely being the defender is not enough. An effect or Arena may remove Defensive Edge.

Tiebreak Roll

[Mechanical change] If tied totals are not resolved by Defensive Edge or another explicit rule, make a separate Tiebreak Roll:

Each player rolls one unmodified die. Higher roll wins. Reroll further ties.

Do not apply advantage, disadvantage, card effects, numerical modifiers, or the previous battle totals unless an effect expressly refers to a Tiebreak Roll.

Retreat and withdrawal

[Clarification] A losing player retreats. A player who leaves a pending or active battle without losing withdraws. Fall Back is ordinary Movement and is neither.

Unless an effect says otherwise:

- an attacking player who retreats or withdraws returns to the Position from which they attacked;
- a defending player who retreats or withdraws moves one Position toward their own end;
- defender-only withdrawal leaves the attacker at the contested Position and may create Occupation;
- mutual withdrawal moves the attacker first, then the defender, and creates no Occupation from that withdrawal.

Withdrawal before Onset prevents the battle and Aftermath. Withdrawal after Onset ends the battle without a winner, then completes the remaining non-result Aftermath and clears committed battle cards normally.

Front Line, Position, and Capture

Contiguous control

[Mechanical change] Your controlled Territories must always form one unbroken line from your own end. That line is your **Front Line**.

Your **Position** is where your Player Token stands. Position and control are separate. A token may stand several Territories beyond its Front Line without controlling those Territories or the intervening ones.

Normal Capture

[Mechanical change] During Capture, identify the next opponent-controlled Territory immediately beyond your Front Line. If your token is on or beyond it, add that Territory to your Front Line.

Normal Capture advances the Front Line by no more than one Territory per turn, regardless of how far the token has advanced. The Territory captured may therefore differ from the Territory containing the token.

Immediate capture effects

[Clarification] Effects that previously appeared to capture a specific occupied Territory cannot create isolated control. Revised effects advance the player's Front Line by the permitted amount, if the token can support each addition.

Deep Position alone does not establish control of the opponent's final Territory or satisfy the normal Last Stand victory sequence.

Faction and Leader changes

Military

- **[Clarification]** Orders are Faction Abilities, not Actions. They occur at their printed timings.
- **[Mechanical change]** Invasion moves from Neutral to Military at cost 4. Its Opening Action grants up to two additional advance-only Positions during that turn's Movement. Its Battle mode gives an attacking Military one additional Reserve card and one additional Tactic.
- **[Mechanical change]** Creating a pending battle loses unused Invasion movement; accepted Terms do not restore it.
- **[Terminology change]** Hold the Line and Shock and Awe now use Onset.
- **[Mechanical change]** Battlefield Promotion and Give Chase are Denouement Actions.
- **[Clarification]** Fortify, Consolidate, and similar effects advance the contiguous Front Line rather than creating isolated control.

The Military alternate victory remains unresolved and is not introduced by v0.6.2.

Diplomats

- **[Clarification]** Proposal cards use explicit player roles because they are physically presented to the receiving player.
- **[Mechanical change]** Accepted unratified Proposals normally grant 1 Influence. Imposed unratified Proposals normally grant 2 Influence. Already-ratified Proposals grant no default ratification reward.
- **[Mechanical change]** Leverage uses triangular total costs: +1 costs 1 Influence, +2 costs 3, +3 costs 6, and +4 costs 10.
- **[Mechanical change]** Détente is a new cost-3 Asset. Once each turn, it grants 1 Influence when an opponent accepts a Proposal that was already ratified when offered.
- **[Clarification]** Good Faith's Accepted result puts the selected card in the Graveyard, then grants 1 Influence.
- **[Clarification]** Gunboat Diplomacy uses its normal role destination: Discard when accepted or normally chosen as a Tactic; Graveyard when set as the refusal Gambit and cleared.
- **[Mechanical change]** Safe Conduct after Onset causes withdrawal and non-result Aftermath rather than a loss.
- **[Clarification]** Diplomatic Recognition advances the Diplomat's Front Line instead of creating isolated control.

The Peace Treaty still requires five different ratified Proposals in v0.6.2. Any later threshold change remains unresolved.

Financiers

- **[Test revision]** Financiers begin with 2 Capital in v0.6.2 testing.
- **[Mechanical change]** Financial Capacity is checked after Capture effects and before Draw. When Treasury value exceeds controlled Territories, the Financier may take one Action during Opening and one during Denouement, provided at least one is a Financier Faction Action.
- **[Clarification]** Financier Faction Actions remain Denouement procedures. Financial Capacity does not permit two Actions in one phase.
- **[Mechanical change]** Compound Interest is a new cost-4 Asset. After the normal Draw, with a nonempty Treasury, its controller may reveal the top Draw Pile card and place it in Treasury or Discard it.
- **[Clarification]** Hostile Takeover and Foreclosure preserve contiguous Front Line control.
- **[Clarification]** Tariffs, Divestment, Margin Loan, and other additional-Action effects use the shared Action rules rather than Action Opportunities.

Line of Credit keeps its existing collateral cap.

Intelligence

- **[Mechanical change]** Extraordinary Rendition is a new cost-4 Asset that binds one revealed opposing Hand card beneath it. The bound card cannot be played, moved, or affected except by Extraordinary Rendition.
- **[Mechanical change]** When Assets are discarded, Extraordinary Rendition must be discarded before other controlled Assets if able. Its bound card then goes to its owner's Discard Pile.
- **[Clarification]** Intelligence Missions and Special Operations taken as Faction Actions are Denouement procedures. Mission Control remains a direct permission that does not use an Action.
- **[Terminology change]** Fieldcraft uses Defensive Edge and Reconnaissance uses Onset.
- **[Clarification]** Counterintelligence and Fog of War no longer rely on obsolete hidden-Territory wording.
- **[Mechanical change]** Sleeper Network may be used as an Action during Opening or Denouement.

Mystics

- **[Clarification]** Begin a Rite and Begin the Ritual of Ascendance are normally Denouement Faction Actions.
- **[Mechanical change]** Guardians of the Circle now requires an Arcane sacrifice of value at least 1 for the first Rite, 2 for the second, 3 for the third, and 4 for the Ritual.
- **[Mechanical change]** Black Covenant grants advantage and may add an additional Tactic or Battle card; both cards go to the Graveyard.
- **[Mechanical change]** Nature's Altar is a new cost-4 Arcane Overlay. It may be placed by Action on the current or adjacent Territory, or after winning on the contested Territory.
- **[Mechanical change]** Nature's Altar creates the special Opening permission to take Begin a Rite while the token is on its Territory. This does not change the Rite's cost or requirements. Same-turn completion applies only if the Altar's controller controls that Territory at completion timing.
- **[Clarification]** Nature's Altar does not waive Rite of Crossing's specialized beginning requirement.

All thirteen Mystics faction cards are Arcane.

Inquisition

- **[Mechanical change]** Purge is a Faction Action legal during Opening or Denouement, normally no more than once per turn. The Inquisition may take an Action in both phases when one of them is Purge, but never two Actions in the same phase.
- **[Clarification]** Final Judgment's Aftermath Purge is a separate Faction Ability. It does not use an Action or consume the normal Purge Faction Action.
- **[Mechanical change]** Martyrdom is a new cost-5 Unique card played after losing, before battle cards clear. Remaining opposing Reserve cards go to the opponent's Graveyard, the Inquisition sets Conviction to 4, and Martyrdom goes to the Graveyard.
- **[Clarification]** Martyrdom does not prevent the loss, retreat, Occupation, or other battle-result consequences.
- **[Clarification]** Relentless Pursuit now follows pending battle, Terms, and Onset without inserting an Opening or Denouement.
- **[Mechanical change]** In an Inquisition mirror, the opposing No Martyrs can prevent the losing player's Martyrdom benefit.

Cards, Territories, and Proposals

New and moved titles

Allegiance	Card	Cost	Summary
Neutral	Landslide	4	Overlay that chains an additional Position of retreat when entered by retreat.
Military	Invasion	4	Moved from Neutral; additional advance movement or expanded attacking battle limits.
Diplomats	Détente	3	Asset rewarding acceptance of already-ratified Proposals.
Financiers	Compound Interest	4	Asset converting the top Draw Pile card into Treasury or Discard after Draw.
Intelligence	Extraordinary Rendition	4	Asset binding an opposing Hand card.
Mystics	Nature's Altar	4	Arcane Overlay enabling a special Opening Rite procedure.
Inquisition	Martyrdom	5	Unique Aftermath response after losing.

The effective pool contains 128 playable card titles: 50 Neutral and 13 for each faction.

Notable inherited compatibility revisions

- Forced March grants Opening movement that cannot create a pending battle.
- Advance Guard grants Opening movement that may create a battle, but no Gambit may be set when its extra Position causes it.
- Entrenchment and Difficult Terrain block Denouement Action cards under their revised timing.
- Palisade Wall uses Onset.
- Reinforcements, Insurrection, and Liberation grant additional Actions without granting same-phase capacity.
- Strategic Withdrawal distinguishes its Opening addition to normal Movement from its Denouement-created later Movement sequence.
- Assimilation advances the Front Line by one.
- Protracted Siege prevents one future attempt to add its Territory to the opposing Front Line.
- Manifest Destiny inserts its blank Territory only when it immediately joins the player's Front Line.
- Quicksand uses Fall Back.
- Command Tent permits one Action in each phase, but both must be card Action effects.
- Smuggler's Pass is an Action during Opening or Denouement.
- Refuge triggers from voluntary Fall Back, not retreat or withdrawal.
- Arenas remove Defensive Edge and use the separate Tiebreak Roll.

What did not change

- A constructed Deck still requires at least 30 cards and no more than 60 total deckbuilding value. The recommended starter Decks are exact 30-card, 60-value lists.
- Players still select one faction and one Leader and use three Territories.
- Gambits, Reserves, Tactics, Outcome, and Aftermath remain the core active-battle stages after Onset.
- A specific card, Territory, Proposal, Leader, or faction rule still overrides a general rule when it directly addresses the situation.
- v0.6.2 does not silently adopt unresolved alternate victories, thresholds, or balance experiments.

Returning-player checklist

Before the first v0.6.2 game:

- use the v0.6.2 starter Deck or rebuild from the full legal pool;
- remember **Capture before Draw**;

- choose whether to use your Action during **Opening** or save it for **Denouement**;
- use **Advance, Hold, or Fall Back** during ordinary Movement;
- stop the Movement sequence when a pending battle is created;
- resolve **Terms before Onset**;
- use **Defensive Edge**, then a separate **Tiebreak Roll** if needed;
- track **Position** separately from the contiguous **Front Line**;
- distinguish **Fall Back, withdrawal, and retreat**;
- review the selected faction's revised timing and its new card;
- use the complete v0.6.2 rules whenever a component-specific interaction is not covered here.

Intentionally unresolved during closeout

The following are not v0.6.2 rules unless a later recorded decision explicitly adopts them before publication:

- Military alternate victory;
- Peace Treaty threshold;
- Leader Ability taxonomy beyond adopted wording;
- unadopted balance experiments.